

In contrast to the more theatrical “talkies,” Fritz Lang’s first sound movie, *M*, uses a complex **sound track** to **build suspense**.

↑
1931

In Germany, studios fall under the control of **Nazi propaganda chief** Joseph Goebbels. Major German directors and stars flee to Hollywood.

↑
1933

Starting with *The 39 Steps*, **Alfred Hitchcock** makes a series of British thrillers that reflect an anxiety about the rise of hostile powers in Europe.

↑
1935

MGM’s Technicolor epic *Gone with the Wind* is an international hit and one of the most **profitable movies ever made**.

↑
1939

1931

↓
Bela Lugosi as **Dracula** and Boris Karloff as **Frankenstein** become horror-movie legends. Depression-era theaters introduce **“double features”**—two full-length movies for the price of one.

1934

↓
Introduced in 1930 by the Motion Picture Producers and Distributors of America as a guideline for **moral decency** in movies, the **Hays Code** is now strictly enforced.

1937

↓
Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs, Walt Disney’s first full-length **animated movie**, becomes an instant classic.

1939

↓
In France, Jean Renoir’s *The Rules of the Game* is a **critical disaster**, but will later be recognized as a brilliant class satire.

In an ordinary Berlin street in 1931, a child is playing. From the shadows nearby, a haunting melody is whistled by a murderer.

The talkies had already made their entrance four years earlier, but this, perhaps, is the moment in cinema when the sound era truly begins. The movie was *M*, a dark thriller by German director Fritz Lang. In that single scene, Lang went far beyond simply adding sound to movies. He was playing with sound, *using* it. He was making it a character’s signature.

Early sound

The first years of sound were a disruptive time for the industry. Many stars lost their careers when they failed the voice test, and there were times when the

“
We are not trying to entertain the critics. I’ll take my chances with the public.
Walt Disney
”

new technology made the movies so cumbersome to produce that some might have been better left silent. Yet the technical troubles were overcome, new stars emerged, and the magic returned. Even today, there are many for whom

movies will never again equal those made in the 1930s and 1940s, the height of the classical Hollywood period. It was an era when, for all the trauma of world events—not least the Great Depression and World War II—movies had swagger, confidence, and mass appeal. They were glamorous and escapist. And they made their audiences laugh. While Charlie Chaplin never fully took to sound (Buster Keaton even less so), others were perfect for it. The Marx Brothers’ verbal virtuosity had their audiences in stitches, while the very essence of screwball comedy was the wisecracking one-liner.

Monster spectacles

While *M* is a good place to open this new era, classical Hollywood’s symbol could be *King Kong* (1933).